decision.

I rang United to try and speak to Steve McClaren. I'd only ever missed one day of training before in nine years as a pro and was sure that, if I explained, the club would understand. I couldn't get through to Steve so I left a message:

'Brooklyn's really struggling. Is it all right if I don't come in? I think I should stay with him.'

No one called back.

In hindsight, the one thing I should have said on that message was that I was calling from London, as opposed to Manchester. The tension between me and the manager over my family life, though, made me guess that just mentioning London would have been enough, on its own, to infuriate him. By ten, Brooklyn had woken up and was obviously much better. Within an hour I was back in the car, on my way to Manchester. I rang Steve and got through to him. It was about midday, when the lads finished training, and I asked him if I should come into Carrington that afternoon to do some work on my own. Steve told meI didn't need to:

'But, David, I should tell you: the manager's not happy.'

I didn't think I'd done anything wrong but, of course, now on the phone to Steve wasn't the time to talk about that. I thought, anyway, that by the following morning everything would have smoothed itself out. I was wrong.

I got into training on the Friday morning and Steve McClaren told me the boss was angry and wanted me to go and see him. I got on with training, assuming I'd talk to the manager afterwards. Instead, while we were in the middle of a possession routine, he came storming over, said something to Steve and then shouted at me:

'Beckham. Here. I want a word.'

Suddenly, I'm in the middle of a row with the Manchester United manager in front of the entire first-team squad. I tried to stand my ground but the boss wasn't having any of it:

'Go and train with the reserves.'

In front of the other lads, that was a huge insult: a huge blow to anyone's